a broad historical consensus that Babur and his progeny were uniquely placed to rule because of the two currents of blue blood that ran in their veins – Babur was descended from two world-conquering kings, the Mongol Chinghis Khan and the Turk Timur. Thus, Stephen Dale writes of how the 'Mughal rulers' . . . genealogies were the envy of their contemporaries' in Turkey and Iran.[5] Such may well have been (or become) the case in neighbouring empires, but on the ground in the Central Asian lands from where the Mughals came – and in the minds of the warlords who came with them – things were more muddled.

Take, for example, Babur's descent from Chinghis Khan, which he claimed from his mother's side, which was Chagatai – descended from (and named after) Chinghis Khan's second son. Chinghis Khan had four sons, however, amongst whom he parcelled out his empire. The eldest, Juchi, ruled over land inhabited by Uzbeks – some of whom, like Babur's great enemy Shaibani Khan (as also Ali Quli Shaibani) claimed descent from Juchi himself. Besides, it is not as if Juchi or Chagatai, or Chinghis Khan himself, for that matter, was the last word in Mongol nobility. Central Asia also had a population of confusingly named Moghuls, descendants of the very first Mongol, Moghul Khan – ancestor not only of Chinghis Khan but of Alanqoa, too. These 'pure' Mongols considered themselves far superior to both the Chagatai, whom they called 'half-breeds' and the Timurids, whom they used to regard as 'nökör', their servants. Thus, as Ali Anooshahr argues, 'Babur's supposedly impeccable lineage, which modern scholars assume gave him legitimacy, in fact counted for little among Moghul aristocrats.'[6]

Not that the Chagatai and Timurids took this lying down. Anooshahr notes how the Chagatai called the Mongols 'bandits'; and Abul Fazl clearly speaks for the Timurids when he describes the early Mongols with some disdain, as living 'far from civilisation', eating 'the produce of hunting and fishing' and wearing 'the skins and fur of . . . animals'.[7]

If Humayun's story shows him unable to control his chiefs, it is not because he was weak, but because they were strong; even Babur, much more authoritative and charismatic than his son, had to deal with noblemen who gave themselves all kinds of airs. This was partly because, as Iqtidar Alam Khan explains, the traditions laid down by Chinghis Khan, the yasa-i-